

IMG-HEAD-v7: Advanced Neuroimaging for Headache

Northstar Imaging Policy

Policy Number: IMG-HEAD-v7

Effective Date: October 1, 2025

SCOPE: MRI and MRA of the head/brain in the evaluation of headache disorders.

MEDICAL NECESSITY: Advanced neuroimaging is considered medically necessary when at least ONE of the following red-flag criteria is documented in the medical record:

- (a) Sudden-onset severe ("thunderclap") headache reaching maximum intensity within one minute.
- (b) New or progressive focal neurologic deficit (motor, sensory, visual, speech) associated with the headache.
- (c) Significant change in headache pattern, frequency, or severity from the member's established baseline.
- (d) Headache in an immunocompromised host or in the setting of active malignancy.
- (e) Papilledema or other signs of increased intracranial pressure.
- (f) Failure of adequate trial of first-line therapy (including at least two preventive agents for chronic migraine).

A prior negative non-contrast CT does NOT preclude MRI when red-flag features are present, as CT has limited sensitivity for posterior fossa lesions, small vascular malformations, and early ischemic change.